

Neoclassicism

The shift in thinking known as the Enlightenment marked a period of intellectual, social and political zeal that began in France in the early 18th century and rapidly spread abroad. Developments in printing had increased literacy among the middle classes, and ideas developed in nearly every aspect of life, including education, economics, law, science and social and political reform. The key terms for the age became order, balance and harmony, and once again the virtues of ancient Greece and Rome were seen as the height of discernment. Neoclassicism was also inspired by discoveries in the 18th century of two ancient Roman cities beneath volcanic ash from the eruption of Mount Vesuvius in 79 CE. It signalled a return to order and rationality after the theatrical baroque and the frivolous rococo (although its earliest traces were apparent in baroque buildings, such as St Paul's Cathedral). Neoclassical architecture is characterized by grandeur of scale, simplicity and geometric forms, Greek or Roman detail, dramatic use of columns and a preference for plain white walls.



Vilnius Roman Catholic Cathedral, Lithuania (1769–83)